

The Indie Founder Survival Guide: Your Relationship to Yourself & Others

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Relationship to Yourself & Others: What this means (and what most people miss)

This area concerns your capacity to be with yourself and others without needing anyone to change. In relation to others, you might have a hard time connecting with people as you are. This can involve trying to manage, change, or help them. You might contort yourself to keep the peace, feel alone when with people, or be in constant conflict. In relation to yourself, you have a hard time being alone and unoccupied. You might be constantly in motion—optimizing or planning—because stillness feels dangerous. You might think you'll rest or be happy later, making the present moment never feel like enough. You may avoid yourself using habits that aren't good long-term, struggling to enjoy your own company without scrolling or drinking.

These patterns stem from the belief that you are not good enough to be accepted as you are. This originates from early experiences where your emotions were too much for adults, love felt conditional or unsafe, vulnerability was dismissed, or your authentic self wasn't safe to express. Not feeling good enough was a survival strategy, but now it blocks deep connection. The solution is not self-improvement or fixing, but getting to know yourself. Believing you need fixing kills the curiosity needed for understanding. Instead of managing others to feel safe, the work is to get to know people and see them deeply. Being seen deeply creates trust, as nobody enjoys being around someone trying to change them. Practicing this brings ease, makes silence peaceful, honesty alive, and love steady. Intimacy becomes

effortless, bringing more presence and joy, and your relationships will blossom.

What it feels like when you're disconnected in relationships

Your responses suggest you regularly feel disconnected from yourself and others. Your relationships may feel superficial despite wanting more depth. You may feel lonely with people. You might push away deep love through jealousy, anger, or defensiveness. It often feels safer to focus on others' opinions rather than your own truth and desires. Speaking up about what you want can feel uncomfortable. In stressful moments, you avoid intensity or act in ways unaligned with who you are. At work, you may overthink, disengage, or become aggressive during hard conversations instead of being honest. Strengthening these relationships helps you speak your truth and build genuine connections.

Patterns to Explore

- **People-pleasing & disconnection:** When you focus on managing how others see you by avoiding conflict or putting on a favorable version of yourself, you lose contact with your own truth. This leads people to connect with a performance, preventing deep connection.
- **Others will feel your agenda:** Steering a conversation toward an outcome—like trying to make someone change or agree—creates resistance. People feel unspoken agendas. Releasing the agenda allows real connection to emerge.
- **Black & white thinking as a signal of fear:** Fear of judgment or rejection collapses openness. We shift into black-and-white thinking and defend ourselves, preventing connection. Recognizing rigid thinking is a clear signal that fear is present.

One experiment for you to try this week: Exploring “how” or “what” questions

When discussing a challenging situation where you want to offer an opinion or jump to a conclusion, ask questions starting with “How” or “What” instead.

- If someone tells you about a problem with their boyfriend, you can ask: “What, if any, help would you like from me about this?”
- If your coworker seemingly steals work from you, you can ask: “What was your thinking behind executing on that task without talking about it?”
- Your boss tells you you did a bad job at something: “What are three ways that I could have handled that better in your mind?”
- If you come home and your partner is mad about the dishes you can ask “How do we set up a world so that neither of us feels badly about the dishes again?”